

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

MONDAY, JULY 6, 2026



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

Asher Fallon received a syringe of food from his mother, Danielle, through his tube at their home in Westerly, R.I.

STUCK AT HOME, WITH MANY NEEDS, LITTLE HELP

R.I. parents of children with disabilities, sickness say schools abandon them

By Steph Machado

GLOBE STAFF

TIVERTON, R.I. — When Michaela Hillyard was born in 2020, doctors said her prognosis was grim.

Her parents were somewhat prepared for the news. Two days before Christmas the previous year, when Abaigeal Hillyard had an ultrasound at 18 weeks, she and her husband, Joshua Hillyard, learned Michaela's brain did not split properly in utero, a rare condition caused by a missing portion of her 13th chromosome. They wouldn't know exactly how it would affect her development until she was born.

"We were advised ... 'Don't get a stroller, you're not going to be taking her home,'"

Abaigeal Hillyard said in an interview in her living room earlier this year. "By the grace of God, we've had three strollers now. And she's outgrown this one."

But, Michaela's disabilities are numerous: She has a feeding tube, is nonverbal, and can't yet walk. She doesn't have thumbs.

And at 6 years old, Michaela also can't go to school in person, her parents said. Her heart, lungs, and kidneys are affected by her condition, and her doctors say she is too immunocompromised for the inside of an elementary school.

She's also, her parents said, not getting the education at home that she's entitled to under a Rhode Island requirement for students who can't go to school for medical rea-

sons.

While the Tiverton schools do provide some services, such as physical therapy and speech therapy, Michaela has never had the five hours a week of instruction required by the Rhode Island Department of Education for homebound special education students. The Hillyards are among multiple families who said they have had to fight to get those services, and feel their children are being left behind.

"As a parent, you get angry," said Abaigeal Hillyard. "It's a place that's supposed to keep your child safe, help your child develop, invest in their education, care about them."

She said a retired special educator cur-

EDUCATE, Page A10

EV sales hit a speed bump, adding pressure on state's climate goals

By Aaron Pressman

GLOBE STAFF

Sales of electric vehicles in Massachusetts short-circuited at the beginning of the year, after the elimination of federal tax credits and a pull-back of new models by the auto industry, according to the most recent state data.

But analysts say the transition to EVs from gas-powered cars, a key part of the state's plan to reduce carbon emissions, is likely to get plugged back in over the next few years, as the cost of EVs drops and the charging infrastructure improves.

Prices are falling fast. More affordable electrics including Rivian's new R2 SUV, starting at \$45,000, and Kia's EV3 crossover, expected to cost about \$35,000, are debuting. And those look positively pricey compared with California upstart Slate's new electric pickup with

an entry version priced around \$25,000. It has no touchscreen, radio, nor even power windows, meaning the truck's "minimalism makes the average Tesla seem lavish," Wall Street Journal car reviewer Dan Neil wrote.

167,000

The number of electric vehicles registered with the Registry of Motor Vehicles in the first quarter of 2026, the first dip in EV registration in four years.

"It's more clear than ever that the transition to electric transportation is going to happen regardless of the decisions happening in Washington," said Daniel Gatti, director of the transportation program at the nonprofit Acadia Center in Maine, pointing to the declining cost of

EVS, Page A7

Waste water monitoring evolves as priorities shift

Biobot proved surveillance works; now governments want it in-house

By Sarah Rahal

GLOBE STAFF

Not long after COVID-19 began spreading in the spring of 2020, a Cambridge startup helped launch a new era of disease surveillance.

Biobot Analytics, founded by two MIT students, transformed the dirty business of sewage into an important new public health tool. By analyzing waste water from treatment plants, the company detected traces of the coronavi-

rus days before infections appeared in hospitals and testing sites, serving as a harbinger of where the disease was spreading — or not — at a time when the nation was in lockdown and on edge.

News organizations began tracking waste water movement much like they would the weather, and Biobot quickly became a reliable indicator for the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, the

WASTE WATER, Page A7

US offers \$1,000 to kick off kids' IRAs

Trump Accounts initiative seeks to broaden investing

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — On America's 250th birthday, the federal government made \$1,000 deposits into millions of investment accounts for toddlers who aren't even old enough to stay up for fireworks.

The launch was for so-called Trump Accounts, an initiative pitched by the president as pro-family to help children build wealth early while simultaneously bolstering the stock market.

Any child under the age of 18 who has a Social Security number is eligible for an account, but for the pilot program only US-children born between 2025 and 2028 can receive the \$1,000.

There are no income requirements or limits that would prevent families from enrolling their children. In addition to the \$1,000 government seed funding, families can contribute up to \$5,000 a year. Investments are restricted to index funds with very low expense fees.

As of mid-June, more than 6 million children have been registered for a Trump Account, according to Treasury data, of which 1.4 million qualify for the \$1,000 in government seed money. Millions more eligible children have not been signed up.

Many applications came during the tax season when people completed Form 4547 ("the most aptly named tax document of all time," in the

ACCOUNTS, Page A6

A mayor in trouble and a city stunned

Brockton residents struggle over Rodrigues allegations

By James Vaznis

GLOBE STAFF

and Thai Theodoro

GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

BROCKTON — When he ran for mayor last fall, Moises Rodrigues vowed to bring stability to Brockton Public Schools pledging every child would have "the tools to succeed — with dignity, preparation, and hope."

His vision in many ways was driven by his journey as a Cape Verdean immigrant. The 64-year-old has long credited his teachers at Brockton High School for helping him learn English and setting him on a successful course in life.

But after being elected mayor, Rodrigues has instead become the central figure in a new level of disruption in the Brockton schools, after two students accused him of inappropriately touching them during school-related activities. The allegations, which occurred about six months after Rodrigues made history as the first Black person elected mayor in Brockton, have stunned many residents and elected officials and prompted an investigation by the Plymouth district attorney.

RODRIGUES, Page B4



Pour, pour pitiful me

Monday: Torrents of rain. High 69-74, low 60-65.

Tuesday: Possible flooding. High 66-71, low 58-63. High tide: 4:04, 4:35.

Sunrise: 5:14. Sunset: 8:24.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**



NEW YORK TIMES

FIFA reversed its ruling, allowing star US striker Folarin Balogun (above) to play against Belgium in their World Cup match. C1, C2.

A series of post-holiday shootings left two dead and 11 hurt in Boston. **B1.**

The Trump administration targets three dozen firearms regulations for dismantling, including abandoning a crack-down on illegal sales. **A2.**

VOL. 310, NO. 6

*

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Treated waste water from the Deer Island Treatment Plant is carried into Massachusetts Bay.